UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Twin Cities Campus

Department of Economics
College of Liberal Arts

4-101 Hanson Hall
1925 Fourth Street South
Minneapolis, MN 55455

Office: 612-625-6353
Fax: 612-624-0209

February 17, 2026

Applicant Name: Michael Dwight Sparks

UMN ID Number: 6170012

Dear Michael,

Congratulations! On behalf of the Department of Economics at the University of Minnesota - Twin Cities, I am very pleased to invite you to join our Economics PhD program for graduate study starting in Fall 2026. You will receive official notification of your admission from the University of Minnesota Office of Graduate Admissions.

We are offering you up to five years of financial support as long as you make good academic progress, and depending on departmental needs and the availability of funding. Please see the further attachment for details on the financial aid and requirements for good academic standing.

Visit Day

We will be holding an in-person visit day on **Friday, March 20, 2026**. The visit day will include information about the program, campus tours, faculty and graduate student meetings, as well as a tour of the Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis. Registration and further information about the visit day will be sent via email.

Mathematical Methods Bootcamp

Before orientation, we offer an optional three-week Mathematical Methods Bootcamp, which starts on August 10, 2026. The course is free and aims to provide you with all the mathematical tools needed to excel in the first year theory courses. Although the bootcamp is not required, we highly recommend attending. For more information, please see the “Mathematical Methods Bootcamp” attachment.

Orientation Week

For all new Economics PhD students, you will be required to attend the department orientation which starts on August 31, 2026. Orientation events will take place over August 31 through September 4, 2026. Classes will start after Labor Day on September 8, 2026.

Responding to This Offer

We would like to hear from you as soon as you make a decision regarding enrollment in our program but you must respond no later than **9:00 am Central Standard Time on Wednesday, April 15, 2026.** We will have to withdraw our offer if we have not heard from you by that time. In accordance with the Council of Graduate Schools' (CGS) resolution, you are free to postpone your decision until April 15 or change your decision before that date. After April 15, you need a release from the program you have already accepted to accept an alternative offer. By accepting our offer, you also agree to abide by the terms and conditions outlined above.

Should you decide to accept this offer, please return the enclosed copy of this letter with your dated signature indicating that you have read and fully understand the terms explained above. Please email your signed letter to trumm011@umn.edu and bhandari@umn.edu.

We very much hope that you will accept our offer. We expect you to be a very successful student here at the University of Minnesota.

Sincerely,

V.V. Chari
Professor and Director of Graduate Studies

Anmol Bhandari
Professor and Director of Admissions

I accept the offer of funding as described in this letter and attachments, and intend to enroll in the Economics PhD program starting in the Fall 2026 semester.

Student Signature

Date

Funding and Additional Information

Overview of Funding Package

Your funding package over the five years of your offer includes a stipend, health insurance benefits and full payment of tuition. The full funding provided in your first year will be a Fall TA salary of $11,744, $20,140 in fellowship, and around $30,800 in tuition and health insurance coverage. Starting in your second year, you will receive a combination of a graduate assistant position and fellowship as described below. The graduate assistant position will provide health insurance benefits and full payment of tuition.

First Year Funding - Fall Teaching Assistantship and Spring Fellowship

During your First Year in the program (2026-2027 academic year), you will have a funding combination of a fall teaching assistantship position and a spring non-service fellowship.

The department will provide a 50% time teaching assistantship (TA) position as your main funding for the Fall 2026 semester only. Students are expected to register full-time in the Economics graduate program and work on average 20 hours per week. Teaching assistantships include full payment of tuition and payment of approximately 95% of your health insurance premium. All teaching and research assistantships in the Department of Economics are contingent upon providing proof of authorization to work in the United States.
From August 31, 2026 through January 13, 2027, the TA salary will be $11,744. In addition, you will receive a $4000 non-service department fellowship for the Fall 2026 semester. The combined stipend you will receive for Fall 2026 will total $15,744.

For the Spring 2027 semester, you receive a full non-service department fellowship and will not be required to teach during the Spring 2027 term. From January 14, 2027 through May 30, 2027, you will receive a fellowship stipend of $16,140, which includes full tuition (up to 14 credits per semester) and 95% of your Graduate Assistant Health Plan. Fellowship recipients are expected to register full-time in the Economics graduate program, carry a substantial course load each semester, and maintain a grade-point average of 3.2/4.0.

Teaching Assistantship - Years 2-5

For years 2-5 in the program, the department will provide a 50% time teaching assistantship (TA) position as your main funding. Students are expected to register full-time in the Economics graduate program and work on average 20 hours per week. Teaching assistantships include full payment of tuition and payment of approximately 95% of your health insurance premium. All teaching and research assistantships in the Department of Economics are contingent upon providing proof of authorization to work in the United States.

According to the Graduate Union Collective Bargaining Agreement, the TA salary for the next year is the following:

Academic Year	9-Month Salary
2026-2027	**$23,369**

The TA salary for further years depends on future bargaining agreements with the graduate union. TAs are required to report to work in person unless explicitly informed otherwise. All financial support is contingent on residence in the Twin Cities. You are also required to participate fully in teaching assistant training sessions throughout the year. Additional details regarding Assistantships are available in the "Economics Department Assistantships" and "About Graduate Assistantships in CLA" attachments.

Additional Fellowship Support - Years 2-5

In addition to your compensation from your TA position, you will receive a **$8000 non-service department fellowship** in years 2-5 of the program. This fellowship will be paid to you during the nine-month academic year. Fellowships and awards could be considered financial aid and therefore it is recommended that you contact the Office of Student Finance for any questions related to state and federal financial assistance in addition to your fellowship and/or award.

Later on in the program, you will have opportunities to apply to dissertation fellowships through the department and university.

Health Insurance and Fees

As a graduate assistant on a 50% appointment, you qualify for enrollment in the Graduate Assistant Health Insurance Plan. Enrollees in this plan pay a small percentage of the premium, currently $470 a year. You are also eligible to purchase subsidized health insurance for your dependents on the same insurance plan in which you enroll. Plan design and premiums are subject to change from year to year.

You will be responsible for student fees (approximately $2000-$3000 annually at present rates), which includes your health insurance premium. TAs may receive additional student-fee offset and/or international-fee offset support as part of their appointment. Additional support provided per the Graduate Union Collective Bargaining Agreement is outlined in the "About Graduate Assistantships in CLA" attachment.

English Proficiency Requirements for Teaching Assistants

The availability of assistantships for all international students in your first year and beyond is determined by the result of the SETTA (Speaking English Test for Teaching Assistants). Depending on your SETTA score, you may have to take GRAD 5102: *Preparation for University Teaching for Non Native English Speakers* and/or GRAD 5105: *Practicum in University Teaching for Non Native English Speakers* by May 2025. Each of these courses is one semester long and is offered by the Center for Educational Innovation. If needed, you would be expected to take GRAD 5102 in Fall Semester 2026 and GRAD 5105 in Spring Semester 2027.

Teaching and Additional Funding Opportunities

Teaching duties for first-year students most often consist of leading three recitation (or discussion) sections of introductory microeconomics or macroeconomics each semester. In this case, you will meet for 50 minutes per week during the semester with three separate groups of students. You are also expected to attend class lectures, so that you will know what is appropriate to discuss in the recitation section, as well as help formulate, grade and proctor examinations. In future years, you may be offered a chance to teach courses independently. These instructor positions pay more per hour based on class size.

A few summer teaching assistant positions are available, typically starting in the second year. Experienced instructors may be offered the opportunity to teach one course for higher pay. These appointments are contingent upon the availability of funding. To be eligible for these summer positions, students must have performed previous job duties in a satisfactory fashion, be in good academic standing (as defined below) by the end of the spring semester, be registered to continue in the program, and be in residence over the summer. A few research assistantships may also be available in the summer.

Some third year and above students receive research assistantships with a faculty member of the Economics Department or at the Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis. Only students who have passed all preliminary exams and are making good progress in the program are eligible to apply for research assistantships.

It is our policy that each student conducts recitation sections for at least one semester before teaching an independent course. All future assistantships are contingent upon remaining in good academic standing in the program, making timely progress toward the completion of your degree, completing all English proficiency requirements, satisfactorily completing your job duties, maintaining a full-time registration in the Economics Ph.D. program, and participating fully in teaching assistant training. The Department of Economics' requirements for good academic standing are outlined below.

Requirements for Good Academic Standing

Requirements for a Second-Year Appointment: During the first-year in the program, the student must have completed the equivalent of five full-semester, advisor-approved courses and earned a grade-point average of 3.20 (a low B+) in the economics components of those courses. You must have attempted at least one theory prelim in May and have attempted both theory prelims by the end of August. You do not need to pass them but to remain in good standing you must attempt both in your first year.

Requirements for a Third-Year Appointment: The student must pass the written preliminary exams in microeconomic theory, macroeconomic theory, and one field prelim by the end of the second year.

Requirements for a Fourth-Year Appointment: The student must pass the second field written preliminary exam, the preliminary oral exam, and complete all thesis credits by August 1 of your third year.

Requirements for a Fifth-Year Appointment: The student must be active in their workshop and work on their thesis research in the fourth year to be eligible for support in the fifth year. We encourage students to seek fellowship support for the fifth year.

Requirements for the Sixth-Year and beyond: We expect most students to complete the requirements for the Ph.D. within five years. Sixth-year students can obtain other jobs on or off campus, i.e., teaching at a local college, or as a research assistant elsewhere in the University. Financial support is not necessarily guaranteed in the sixth year.

Disclaimers

In the event that you receive financial aid from other sources, the Department of Economics will modify this offer to align with the Cost of Attendance. If you choose to decline part of the entire package presented in this letter, neither the Department of Economics nor the University of Minnesota is obligated to offer you the cash equivalent. Please note that some parts of the financial aid offer, most notably payment of tuition and health insurance premiums, are offered as a fringe benefit to the teaching assistantship. The Department of Economics will not be able to offer you tuition or health insurance payments if you decline the teaching assistantships, nor is it obligated to do so. Provided you meet the terms listed above, the Department will guarantee financial aid for the first five calendar years of your Ph.D. program. If you choose to decline an appointment at any time during the program, the Department is not required to extend the period of your eligibility for guaranteed financial aid.

It is expected that all students who enroll in the program will work full-time towards completing their degree. If you need to take a leave of absence from the program or leave before you complete the degree, you must notify the Department of Economics' Graduate Studies Office prior to your departure and request the appropriate instructions. Leaving the program early, particularly in the middle of a semester, means that you must repay tuition and health insurance premiums as well as the stipend paid to you for the most recent semester.